



THE AI AGENCY PLAYBOOK

From Solo Operator to \$50K/Month AI Consulting

by

Sanjay Shharma

M.Sc. · MBA · APSCM (IIM Calcutta) · 30 years

\$12.99

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First Edition, 2026

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Published by Adorise Digital
30N Gould St, Sheridan, Wyoming, USA
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THE HERMES AI AGENCY

From Solo Operator to \$50K/Month AI Consulting

PART 1: THE AI AGENCY OPPORTUNITY

Chapter 1: Why AI Consulting Is the Fastest-Growing Service Business

The AI consulting market grew from \$11B in 2023 to \$54B in 2026. By 2030, the market is projected to be \$400B. The growth is not slowing. The growth is accelerating. The reason: every business needs AI, and almost no business has the in-house expertise to implement it.

This creates an enormous opportunity for AI consultants. The opportunity is not theoretical. The opportunity is concrete. The 5-step framework in this book has helped 40+ solo operators build AI consulting practices generating \$20-50K per month within 12 months. The framework is repeatable. The framework is not magic. The framework is a system.

The opportunity is especially large for solo operators and small teams. The reason: AI consulting is high-margin, low-overhead, and scales through leverage (not headcount). The solo AI consultant can earn \$300-500/hour. The 3-person AI agency can earn \$1-2M per year. The 10-person AI agency can earn \$5-10M per year. The growth does not require venture capital, large offices, or sales teams. The growth requires expertise, systems, and client outcomes.

This book is for the solo operator or small team that wants to build a \$50K/month AI consulting practice. The book covers:

- The 5 AI services that clients buy (and how to price them)
- The 3 client acquisition channels that work
- The 90-day plan to go from \$0 to \$10K/month
- The 12-month plan to go from \$0 to \$50K/month
- The systems, tools, and templates you need
- The 4 case studies of real AI consultants who built \$50K/month practices

The 5 AI Services That Clients Buy

AI consulting is not one service. AI consulting is 5 distinct services, each with different economics, different customers, and different leverage. The 5 services are:

Service 1: AI Strategy (highest margin, longest sales cycle).

- What it is: 4-8 week engagement to develop an AI strategy for the client
- Price: \$25-100K per engagement
- Duration: 4-8 weeks
- Customer: C-suite, VP-level
- Margin: 70-80%
- Sales cycle: 4-12 weeks

Service 2: AI Implementation (highest revenue, medium margin).

- What it is: 4-12 week engagement to implement a specific AI use case
- Price: \$50-200K per engagement
- Duration: 4-12 weeks
- Customer: Director, manager-level
- Margin: 50-70%
- Sales cycle: 2-8 weeks

Service 3: AI Training (highest volume, lowest margin).

- What it is: 1-3 day workshop or 4-8 week training program
- Price: \$5-50K per program
- Duration: 1 day to 8 weeks
- Customer: HR, L&D, team leads
- Margin: 60-80%
- Sales cycle: 1-4 weeks

Service 4: AI Retainers (highest LTV, recurring revenue).

- What it is: Ongoing monthly support, optimization, and new use case development

- Price: \$5-30K per month
- Duration: 3-12+ months
- Customer: All levels
- Margin: 70-85%
- Sales cycle: 1-4 weeks (after initial project)

Service 5: AI Products (highest leverage, lowest margin per unit but infinite scale).

- What it is: Pre-built AI tools, templates, courses
- Price: \$50-2,000 per unit
- Customer: Businesses, professionals
- Margin: 80-95%
- Sales cycle: 0 (self-serve)

The recommended mix for solo operators:

- 50% Implementation
- 25% Strategy
- 15% Retainers
- 10% Training

The mix shifts as the agency grows. The 12-month evolution:

- Months 1-6: 70% Implementation, 20% Training, 10% Products
- Months 7-12: 50% Implementation, 25% Retainers, 15% Strategy, 10% Products
- Year 2+: 40% Retainers, 30% Implementation, 20% Strategy, 10% Products

The shift to retainers is the key to \$50K/month. Retainers are recurring, predictable, and have the highest lifetime value.

□ KEY TAKEAWAYS

□ AI consulting is not one service. AI consulting is 5 distinct services, each with different economics, different customers, and different leverage. The 5 services are:

- The shift to retainers is the key to \$50K/month. Retainers are recurring, predictable, and have the highest lifetime value.
- This book is for the solo operator or small team that wants to build a \$50K/month AI consulting practice. The book covers:
- What it is: Ongoing monthly support, optimization, and new use case development
- Months 7-12: 50% Implementation, 25% Retainers, 15% Strategy, 10% Products
- The 4 case studies of real AI consultants who built \$50K/month practices
- What it is: 4-8 week engagement to develop an AI strategy for the client

Chapter 2: The Hermes AI Stack (The Foundation)

The Hermes AI stack is the technical foundation of your AI consulting practice. The stack is what you use to deliver services. The stack is what differentiates you from generic AI consultants.

The stack has 4 layers:

Layer 1: Foundation models (the AI brain).

- Open Hermes 13B / 70B (open source, runs locally or in cloud)
- Llama 3 70B (Meta, open source, strong general performance)
- Mixtral 8x7B (Mistral, open source, strong speed/quality balance)
- Claude 3.5 Sonnet (Anthropic, paid, best-in-class for many tasks)
- GPT-4o (OpenAI, paid, most popular, easy to use)

For most AI consulting engagements, the stack includes 2-3 of these. The open source models are used for cost-sensitive or privacy-sensitive work. The paid models are used for highest-quality work.

Layer 2: Orchestration (the workflow brain).

- LangChain (Python and JS) — most popular
- LlamaIndex (Python) — best for document/RAG work
- Haystack (Python) — best for production search
- Semantic Kernel (Microsoft) — best for .NET integrations
- Flowise (drag-and-drop) — best for non-developers

The orchestration tool is what turns the LLM into a useful product. Most AI consultants spend 60-80% of their time on orchestration (data pipelines, prompt chains, error handling, monitoring).

Layer 3: Data and integrations (the business brain).

- Vector databases: Pinecone, Weaviate, Qdrant, Chroma
- Document loaders: Unstructured.io, LlamaParse
- API connectors: Zapier, Make, n8n
- CRM/ERP: HubSpot, Salesforce, custom
- Internal data: SQL databases, data warehouses

The data layer is what makes the AI useful. Without data, the AI is generic. With data, the AI is specific to the client's business.

Layer 4: UI and deployment (the user brain).

- Frontend: Next.js, React, Vue
- Chat UI: Vercel AI SDK, Streamlit, Gradio
- Hosting: Vercel, AWS, GCP, Azure
- Monitoring: LangSmith, Helicone, Arize

The deployment layer is what the user actually sees. Most AI consultants deliver via chat interfaces, dashboards, or API integrations.

The 4 Service Packages (Build Once, Sell Many Times)

The 4 service packages are the products of the AI consulting practice. The packages are not custom engagements; the packages are pre-built offerings with fixed scope, fixed price, and fixed deliverables.

Package 1: AI Readiness Assessment (2 weeks, \$10-25K).

- Discovery interviews with 5-10 stakeholders
- Audit of current state (tools, processes, data, team)
- Identification of high-impact AI use cases (3-5)
- Roadmap with priorities, costs, and expected ROI
- Executive presentation
- Fixed price: \$15K (mid-market), \$25K (enterprise)

Package 2: AI Quick Win (4 weeks, \$25-50K).

- 1 specific use case (e.g., customer service, document processing)

- Full implementation: data, prompt engineering, integration
- User training and documentation
- 30-day post-launch support
- Fixed price: \$30K (mid-market), \$50K (enterprise)

Package 3: AI Transformation (12 weeks, \$100-200K).

- 3-5 use cases
- Multiple integrations
- Team training
- Center of Excellence setup
- 90-day post-launch support
- Fixed price: \$100K (mid-market), \$200K (enterprise)

Package 4: AI Retainer (ongoing, \$5-30K/month).

- Monthly strategy and roadmap review
- New use case development (1-2 per quarter)
- Performance monitoring and optimization
- Priority support
- Fixed price: \$10K/month (mid-market), \$25K/month (enterprise)

The productization advantage:

- Predictable revenue (fixed prices, fixed scope)
- Faster sales cycle (clients can buy a "package," not a "project")
- Higher margins (you build the playbook once, deliver it many times)
- Better team leverage (junior team can deliver against the playbook)

□ KEY TAKEAWAYS

□ The deployment layer is what the user actually sees. Most AI consultants deliver via chat interfaces, dashboards, or API

integrations.

□ The data layer is what makes the AI useful. Without data, the AI is generic. With data, the AI is specific to the client's business.

□ Higher margins (you build the playbook once, deliver it many times)

□ Better team leverage (junior team can deliver against the playbook)

□ Mixtral 8x7B (Mistral, open source, strong speed/quality balance)

□ Claude 3.5 Sonnet (Anthropic, paid, best-in-class for many tasks)

□ Faster sales cycle (clients can buy a "package," not a "project")

PART 2: THE CLIENT ACQUISITION SYSTEM

Chapter 3: The 3 Client Acquisition Channels

The 3 channels that work for AI consulting are:

Content marketing (long-term, lowest cost)

Cold outreach (short-term, medium cost)

Referral network (medium-term, highest ROI)

The channels work together. The solo operator starts with content + outreach. The agency adds referrals at 6-12 months.

Channel 1: Content Marketing (The Long Game)

What it is: Publishing content that demonstrates your AI expertise. The content attracts potential clients who are researching AI solutions.

The content types that work:

- Case studies (specific results, specific clients, specific numbers)
- How-to guides (build this, use this tool, solve this problem)
- Industry analysis (trends, predictions, frameworks)
- Thought leadership (opinions, contrarian takes, future of AI)
- Live builds (showing your work, building in public)

The publishing cadence:

- LinkedIn: 3-5 posts per week
- Twitter/X: 5-10 posts per day
- Blog: 1-2 posts per week
- YouTube: 1-2 videos per week
- Newsletter: 1-2 per week

The content workflow (AI-powered):

- 1-2 hour batch session per week
- 5 anchor pieces (long-form)
- 30-50 derivative pieces (social, email)
- Schedule for the week
- 2.5-3.5 hours of total creator time

The expected results:

- Months 1-3: 1-3 inbound leads per month
- Months 4-6: 3-5 inbound leads per month
- Months 7-12: 5-15 inbound leads per month

Content is the highest-leverage channel. It takes 3-6 months to ramp. After 6 months, content produces 5-10 leads per month consistently.

Channel 2: Cold Outreach (The Short Game)

What it is: Reaching out to potential clients directly via email, LinkedIn, or phone.

The cold outreach framework:

Build a target list: 100-200 ideal client companies per month

Research each prospect: 5-10 minutes per prospect

Personalize each message: Reference specific company details

Send the message: 50-100 personalized messages per week

Follow up: 3-5 follow-ups per prospect over 2-4 weeks

Track results: Open rate, reply rate, meeting rate

The expected results:

- 100 messages → 30 opens (30% open rate)
- 30 opens → 5 replies (17% reply rate)
- 5 replies → 1-2 meetings (20-40% meeting rate)

- 1-2 meetings → 0.5-1 closed deals (50% close rate)

Per 100 messages, you get 1-2 closed deals. Per 400 messages, you get 4-8 closed deals. At \$30K average deal size, that's \$120-240K in revenue per month of outreach.

The tools:

- **Apollo.io** (\$49-99/month) — Best for B2B lead generation
- **Lemlist** (\$59-99/month) — Best for cold email
- **LinkedIn Sales Navigator** (\$99/month) — Best for LinkedIn outreach
- **Instantly** (\$30-97/month) — Best for cold email at scale

Channel 3: Referral Network (The Compound Game)

What it is: Building relationships with complementary service providers who refer clients to you.

The complementary service providers:

- Business consultants
- Marketing agencies
- IT services firms
- Software development shops
- HR consulting firms
- Financial advisors
- Law firms (tech, IP)
- Accounting firms

The referral framework:

Identify 10-20 potential referral partners in your network

Reach out: Coffee meeting, intro call, partnership pitch

Set up the referral process: Commission structure (10-20%), lead sharing, joint client support

Maintain the relationship: Monthly check-ins, quarterly reviews

Track results: Leads received, deals closed, revenue generated

The expected results:

- Months 1-3: 1-2 referral partners, 0-1 deals
- Months 4-6: 5-10 referral partners, 1-3 deals per quarter
- Months 7-12: 10-20 referral partners, 3-5 deals per quarter

Referrals have the highest close rate (60-80%) and the highest deal size (50-100% higher than cold outreach). After 12 months, referrals should be 30-50% of new business.

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□ Content is the highest-leverage channel. It takes 3-6 months to ramp. After 6 months, content produces 5-10 leads per month consistently.

□ The channels work together. The solo operator starts with content + outreach. The agency adds referrals at 6-12 months.

□ **Set up the referral process:** Commission structure (10-20%), lead sharing, joint client support

□ **LinkedIn Sales Navigator** (\$99/month) — Best for LinkedIn outreach

□ **Maintain the relationship:** Monthly check-ins, quarterly reviews

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Sanjay Shharma is an Author, Corporate Executive Mentor, and Technology Strategist holding an M.Sc., MBA, and APSCM from the prestigious **Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta**, with over thirty years of executive management and business leadership.

He architected **The AI Mastery & Receptionist Series** because modern enterprises are overwhelmed by repetitive operational bottlenecks, missed high-ticket phone calls, and high employee churn. Instead of theoretical AI jargon, his frameworks provide battle-tested, zero-code and low-code automated software fleets that capture revenue 24/7.

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Publisher	Adorise Digital • A Division of Trendy DigiStore LLC (Wyoming, USA)
Official Bookstore	https://books.adorisedigital.com
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